members, so government ally BJP sees a dividend in the civic polls

**DIRECT ELECTIONS IN CIVIC BODIES**
**Thackeray:** Stopped direct elections to post of president (municipal councils) and sarpanch (panchayats)
**Result:** As the presidents were elected from among the councillors, the then ruling Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) had an edge
**Shinde:** Allowed direct elections
**Status:** Decision will be implemented in the coming civic bodies' polls
**Impact:** Shinde faction of the Shiv Sena and ally BJP are at a political advantage as direct elections are likely to work in their favour

**FARMERS' VOTING RIGHTS**
**Thackeray:** Had withdrawn voting rights of farmers in electing members of the Agriculture Produce Marketing Committees (APMCs)
**Result:** APMC members were elected by members of village panchayat, agriculture credit societies and multi-purpose credit societies dominated by the Congress and the NCP
**Shinde:** Restored the farmers' rights in AMPC polls. Farmers with 0.25 acres of land who have sold their produce in the APMC market at least three times in the past five years are eligible to vote
**Status:** Decision will be implemented in APMC election due next year
**Impact:** Shinde faction and BJP may be able to sway the farmers, break the Congress-NCP monopoly

**BMC WARDS**
**Thackeray:** Increased number of wards from 227 to 236 in Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), changed boundaries of several wards
**Result:** Sena was at an advantage with changed boundaries; core voters largely accommodated
**Shinde:** Restored number of wards to 227, cancelled the delimitation
**Status:** Process for reserving wards for SCs, women to start soon
**Impact:** Shinde's cohorts and BJP hope to corner Thackeray faction outside the Marathi-dominated areas.



**LATE CHECK-UP**
Telangana minister T. Harish Rao visits a woman sterilised at the CHC in hospital

surgeries were done with no reports of fatalities. Now, all DPL procedures at government hospitals are on hold. Twenty-four of those operated upon in the CHC that day were admitted to different hospitals in Hyderabad after the tragedy. "By sending the survivors to hospitals, the government admits its health services are substandard," claims M. Ranga Reddy, a former Congress MLA.

The Congress and the BJP have demanded state health minister T. Harish Rao's resignation and action against the health officials. "The government has conducted 700,000 sterilisation surgeries in seven years and no such incident has ever been reported," minister Rao countered. However, Telangana governor Tamilisai Soundararajan sought a detailed report, and the National Commission for Women has constituted a two-member inquiry team for an independent probe.

"We are awaiting forensic reports to find out if there was a problem with the [surgical] instruments or outside food," says Dr J. Ajaya Kumar, commissioner of the Vaidya Vidhana Parishad, a division of the health department. He ruled out the surgeon being at fault. As a fallout of the deaths, Telangana may not meet its annual sterilisation target. Officials deny a goal has been set—since 2016, the state's fertility rate has been below the replacement level of 2.1 children per woman. ■

KARNATAKA

# Fall from Grace

By Ajay Sukumaran

An uneasy calm prevailed at Chitradurga's famous Murugha matha this past weekend, shaken as it was by allegations that the 64-year-old pontiff, Shivamurthy Murugha Sharanaru, had sexually assaulted two minor girls who had been staying in a hostel run by the matha. The pontiff was arrested on September 1, nearly a week after an FIR was registered against him following the testimony of the two teenagers, aged 15 and 16. The alleged sexual abuse, one of them said in the complaint, had taken place over a period of three years. While the police faced criticism for delaying the arrest of the pontiff, Karnataka's political parties have shied away from public comment.

Nestled between two lakes against a backdrop of rocky hillocks on the Chitradurga-Davanagere highway in central Karnataka, Sri Jagadguru Murugharajendra Brihanmatha is one of Karnataka's oldest and most prominent Lingayat mathas, tracing its current line of pontiffs back to the 16th century.



**NO ESCAPE**
Pontiff Shivamurthy Sharanaru in custody